

Now & Then

Weekly current events routine 8th Grade Social Studies About 10 minutes,
once a week

One short bellringer each week. Students connect a

piece of today's news to whatever unit you are studying.

It builds a running record in the Bellringer Notebook that

students draw on for the end of year civic action

capstone, so the routine does double duty.

The weekly rhythm

1. Now (3 min). Students read or watch a

short news item. You can post one for the whole

class, or let students bring their own once the

routine is rolling.

2.Source check (2 min). A quick SIFT pass

(a four step habit for checking if a source can be

trusted: Stop, Investigate the source, Find better

coverage, Trace the claim back to where it

started). Students mark whether the source seems

trustworthy and why.

3.Then (3 min). Students link the story to

the unit. Every unit has a "Then anchor" on the

last sheet of this packet to make the link easy.

4. So what (2 min). One sentence: why this

connection matters, or what it predicts.

Why it works

It hits the history to today standard every single week instead of once a year, keeps source skills warm, and quietly grows the evidence file students will turn into their civic action project. No new prep days. It lives inside the warm up you already run.

Standards it carries

•**H4.6-8.3** Analyze how a historical event

helps us understand a current issue. (every week)

•**SSS1.6-8.1 / SSS2.6-8.2** Weigh evidence

and judge whether a source is reliable.

•**SS3.6-8.1** When you run a few of these

as quick partner talks, students practice hearing

more than one viewpoint.

•**C4.6-8.5** The running log feeds the year

end civic action capstone, which is where this

standard gets met.

Keeping it accessible

- Use the Support version (next pages) for

students who need sentence stems and a word

bank.

- Let students choose to write, draw, or talk

their connection. A two panel "then and now"

sketch counts.

- Curate two or three trusted sources for the

week so no one is lost in a search.

- Keep a class running wall: "Stories we

connected this year." It becomes a memory aid for

the capstone.

Now & Then Weekly Bellringer — Teacher Guide — Mr.

B's Social Studies

Bellringer

Now & Then

Name: _____ Date: _____ Unit: _____

1. Now: the story

Headline: _____

Where it came from (the source): _____

Source check (SIFT)

Do you trust this source? Yes / Not sure / No

One reason: _____

In two or three sentences, what is happening?

2. Then: the connection

How does this connect to what we are studying right now? Name the link.

3. So what?

Finish this thought in one sentence: This matters because . . .

Now & Then — Mr. B's Social Studies

Support Version

Bellringer

Now & Then

Name: _____ Date: _____ Unit: _____

1. Now: the story

Headline: _____

The source (who told the story): _____

Do you trust the source? Yes / Not sure / No

A source you can trust is honest, recent, and not trying to trick you.

What is happening? Use the stems.

- The news is about _____.
- It is happening in _____.
- The main thing to know is _____.

2. Then: the connection

Use a stem to link the news to our unit.

- This reminds me of _____ from class.
- Back then, people _____. Today, people _____.

_____.

Word bank for this unit: _____ (your teacher fills these in)

3. So what?

- This matters because _____.

You may draw a two box "then and now" picture instead of writing.

Then

Now

Now & Then (Support) — Mr. B's Social Studies
Teacher Reference

"Then" Anchors by Unit

What today's news can connect back to

Each unit has a big idea that today's news keeps echoing. Point students at the anchor, then let them find the modern story (or you provide one). Sample current themes are just starting points.

Unit	"Then" anchor (the big idea)	Modern stories that echo it
0. Identity	Who counts as American, and who gets to decide	Citizenship and immigration debates; who is included
1. 13 Colonies	Who controls land, labor, and trade	Land use fights; who does the work in an economy
2. Triangle Trade	Wealth built on other people's labor; profit vs. human cost	Supply chains; unfair labor; where our goods come from
3. Revolutionary Voices	Protest, rights, and whose voice gets heard	Movements and protests; petitions; free speech

4. The Constitution	Limits on power; rights protected from government	Court rulings; Congress vs. president; rights cases
6. SCOTUS	How courts decide what the Constitution means	Current Supreme Court cases and decisions
7. Early Republic	Party conflict, foreign entanglements, freedom vs. safety	Polarization; U.S. role abroad; free speech vs. security
8. Westward Expansion	Land, removal, and tribal sovereignty	Tribal land and treaty news; borders; resource disputes
9. Civil War	A nation divided; region, rights, and memory	Political division; voting rights; monuments and memory

Feeds the capstone

Tell students to star any entry tied to an issue they care about. At year's end they pick one starred thread and turn it into their civic action project. The research is already done, spread across the whole year.

Now & Then — "Then" Anchors by Unit — Mr. B's Social Studies